

ICELAND

Day 1: Around Reykjavik.

This route flows mostly downhill and is roughly 2 miles (3 km) of walking,

Hallgrímskirkja Church & Rainbow Street: Start your tour at **Hallgrímskirkja**, the towering concrete church that defines the city's skyline. Its design mimics Iceland's natural basalt lava columns. Step inside to see the massive 25-ton pipe organ, and if you want the absolute best view of Reykjavik's colorful rooftops, take the elevator up to the tower observation deck (requires a small fee).

Walk out the front doors and head straight down **Skólavörðustígur**, famously known as the **Rainbow Street**, which is painted in vibrant colors leading directly toward the church.

Sun Voyager & Waterfront Stroll: From the bottom of the Rainbow Street, cut north toward the ocean (~10 minute walk) to reach the **Sun Voyager (Sólfarið)** sculpture. This striking stainless-steel artwork resembles a Viking longship and looks out across Faxaflói Bay toward Mount Esja. Enjoy a brisk, scenic 10-minute walk west along the paved seaside path heading toward the harbor.

Harpa Concert Hall: Arrive at **Harpa**, a masterpiece of modern architecture. Its exterior is wrapped in over 10,000 geometric glass panels designed by artist Olafur Eliasson to mimic the basalt landscape and capture the shifting Icelandic light. It is free to walk inside the foyer—the honeycomb windows create incredible kaleidoscopic patterns on the floor. Go upstairs for great views.

Old Harbor: Walk out of Harpa and amble into the historic Old Harbor district.

Parliament Square & Tjörnin Lake: Head slightly inland to **Austurvöllur Square**, the public heart of the city, bordered by the classic stone Parliament Building (**Alþingi**) and the Reykjavik Cathedral. Walk just a minute south to **Tjörnin (The Pond)**. This peaceful city lake is bordered by beautiful old houses and is constantly bustling with swans and ducks.

Reykjavik City Hall: Finish your tour by stepping inside **Reykjavik City Hall**, situated right on the edge of the water. Inside the lobby, there is a massive, highly detailed **3D topographical map of Iceland**.

Day 2: The Golden Circle: 270 kms. Takes around 3 hr and 59 min

<https://adventures.is/iceland/attractions/golden-circle/>



1. Þingvellir: 45 min from Reykjavik is a National park. It's also the birthplace of Iceland's ancient parliament, Alþingi. Sights are scattered throughout the area. The Park's Visitor Center is located near the P1 parking lot. If you go east from the visitor center, you'll find Silfra fissure. Going north, there's a bridge that crosses the Þeningagjá fissure. Going straight from the center will take you to Þingvellir Church. If you go through the Almannagjá canyon, you'll be surrounded by continental plates. Past Snorri's Booth, a landmark related to the Icelandic poet and historian, you'll find the supposed location of The Law Rock. A few more steps to the right and you'll see Drekkingshryllur pond. In both cases, if you continue north, you'll reach the narrow path that leads to Öxarárfoss waterfall. Another place you can visit is Þingvallavatn lake, the biggest natural lake in Iceland. It supplies clear water to Silfra Fissure. Plan to spend around 1 ½ hr.

P1 (Hakid) sits at the upper end of Almannagja Gorge by the Visitor Center, which is the most popular entry point. P2 (Efri-Vellir) is below the Oxararfoss Waterfall. P3 (Langistigur) is 2,950 feet (900 meters) north of the falls. P5 (Valholl) is closest to the Þingvellir Church and the Silfra Fissure.

From P1, you can walk through Almannagja Gorge, one of the clearest places to see the North American and Eurasian tectonic plates, and down to the location of Iceland's medieval parliament, the Alþingi, founded in 930.

*Efstidalur Dairy Farm - between Pingvellir and Geysir, famous for its farm to table ice cream. It opens at 10 am.

2. 40 min drive gets to the Haukadalur Geothermal Area. Here, you'll find world-famous geysers: the sleeping Great Geysir and active Strokkur erupting hot water high into the air every 4-10 minutes. Plan to spend around 1 hr.
3. 10 min from Geysir is Gullfoss Falls: The upper parking lot is close to the Gullfoss Visitor Center, where you'll find restrooms, a souvenir shop, and a café. From P1 lot, you can take a short hike down to P2 area for a closer view of the falls. A 2 km (1.2 mi) round-trip walking trail to the falls takes 15 to 30 minutes to complete. The Geysir Center across the road has restaurants, restrooms, a souvenir shop, and Hotel Geysir. Plan for 1 hr.
4. Faxi Waterfall: was featured in Game of Thrones. As you continue on route 36 after the Geysir, you'll need to take the route east for 17.3 km, followed by a left to Route 48. After another 5.6 kilometers, you'll find a sign that marks an exit to the falls. From the parking lot, take a few steps to enjoy the stunning view of the falls.

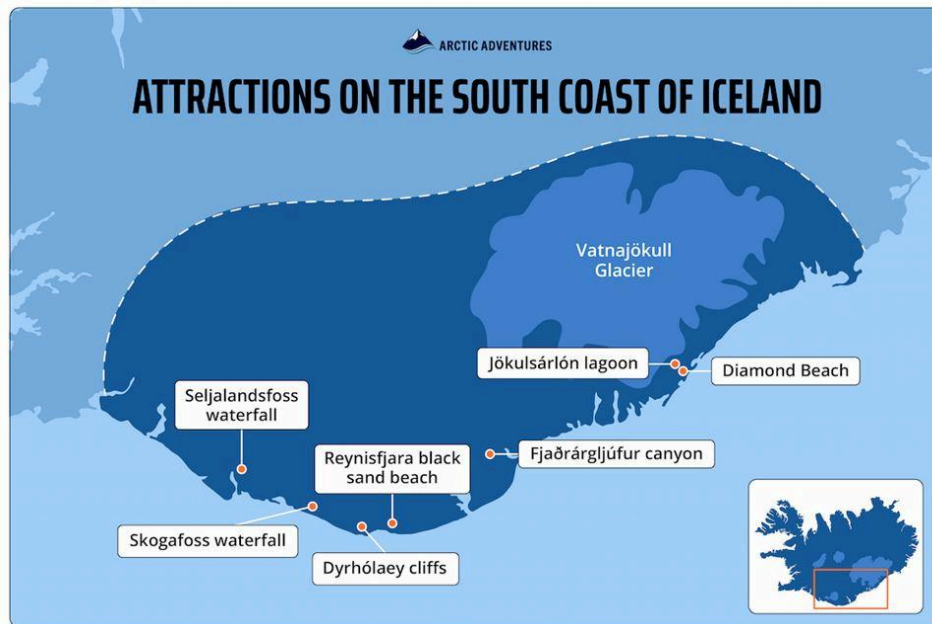
****Friðheimar, a family run tomato farm & restaurant** is easy to find, as it is right off the highway on the Golden Circle tour route, but look out for the sign. It can be easy to miss! 30 min **From Geysir**, take Route 35 via Biskupstungnabraut. The prices are very reasonable, for a soup with home-baked bread and coffee/tea it is around 2000 ISK.

5. Secret Lagoon: Reservation for 6 pm. 30 min from Gullfoss.
6. Kerid Crater Lake: 30 min from Secret lagoon, near Selfoss town on Iceland's Golden Circle, the enormous crater Kerið is the perfect point to finish the route. Also called the 'Eye of the World', stunning red volcanic rock crater. The caldera against the turquoise-blue water is captivating. 30-40 min.

****About 9 miles (15 kilometers) south of Gullfoss on Route 35, the Kerid Crater is a popular fourth stop on the Golden Circle loop, especially for travelers driving the alternative southern route. Parking is free, but the Kerid entrance fee is about 700 ISK (5 USD) per person.**

7. Located close to Flúðir town, Secret Lagoon is Iceland's oldest natural pool, dating back to 1891. It is located in a geothermal area, so you can even see a small erupting geyser nearby.

Day 3: The South Island



Must-See Stops & Driving Distances

Starting east from Reykjavík, the drive is entirely paved and easily navigable.

- **Seljalandsfoss Waterfall:** Located 120 km (75 miles) east of Reykjavík. You can take a trail that circles directly behind the falling water. Just a short walk from Seljalandsfoss, **Gljúfurárfoss** is a magical waterfall tucked into a crack in the cliff.
- **Skógafoss Waterfall:** 30 km (18 miles) past Seljalandsfoss. A towering 60-meter drop where you can climb the stairs to the top. [
- **Sólheimajökull Glacier:** A 10 km drive off Route 1. A striking mix of white, blue, and black ice streak across the glacier's surface, creating dramatic ridges and patterns. Easy 10 min walk to the glacier from the parking lot. If you plan to stop for fuel, food, or restrooms, the town of Hvalsvollur is the most convenient place to pause along the route.

- **Dyrhólaey Cliffs:** There are two parking areas. The lower parking lot gives you access to Kirkjufjara beach and the main puffin viewing boardwalks. During the day, they are often out fishing, so it is best to try to see them in the evening when they are most active. Visitor hours are restricted during puffin season (around April to August) and Dyrhólaey will be closed from 7 pm.
- **Reynisfjara Black Sand Beach:** Near the town of Vík, 187 km (116 miles) from Reykjavík. a notorious black-sanded beach in the south of Iceland. This beach is known for a phenomenon called "sneaker waves." It is when the waves can become very fierce at any moment, so you have to be cautious at all times. Other strong features of this beach are basalt cave and Reynisdrangar rock stacks rising from the sea. Sneaker waves can form even on calm days—mini tsunamis that strike the shore suddenly and without warning.
- **Fjaðrárgljúfur Canyon:** The most famous canyon in Iceland. Known for its unique serpentine shape, 50 min from Vík to the east. Restrooms available at the main parking lot. A short walk from the upper parking to the main canyon's viewpoint is perfect for those seeking a relaxed experience. Once there, a flat path leads to the vantage point with a breathtaking canyon panorama.
- **Vatnajökull National Park:** Home to the Skaftafell area, located 325 km (202 miles) from the capital, offering excellent glacier views and hiking trails.
- **Diamond Beach:** is one of the best stops on the South Coast. 20 min from Vík.
- **Jökulsárlón Glacier Lagoon:** Massive icebergs float in the lagoon before washing up on the contrasting black sands of Diamond Beach. Located just a 3-minute drive from Diamond Beach.